face and muttered something supposed to be a prayer. We concluded by making the motion of stroking our beards.'

One-half of the armed troops who were lined either side of the avenue were then ordered to withdraw, and they went out at a trot, their breastplates and dented pauldrons clanking against each other, 'making as much rattle with their armour and clatter on the pavement as they could'. When they had retired a court official stood before Elphinstone, 'and called out in a loud voice looking up to the King, this is Mr Alfinistan Bahadur Furingee, the Ambassador, God bless him; then Astarji Bahadur [Mr Strachey] and so successively down the line, but had increasing difficulty managing our uncouth names, such as Cunninghame, McCartney, Fitzgerald, and by the time he had passed nearly through, blundered out any sound that struck him.'

When their names had been gone through, the diplomats stood for a minute in perfect silence and stillness, until Shah Shuja 'in a very loud and audible voice' uttered from aloft 'Khush Amuded' – you are welcome. Shuja then left his high gilt throne in the front of the building and, helped down by two eunuchs, walked to a low *takht* [throne dais] in the corner of the hall. When he was seated, the diplomats advanced up the cypress avenue, and into the arcaded hall of audience. 'On entering we ranged ourselves along the side of the apartment, where the floor was covered with the richest carpets. The silence was first broken, by the King's asking if His British Majesty, the Padshah o Ungraiseestan, and his Nation were all well and that the British and his nation had always been on the best terms, and trusted would always remain so. To which Elphinstone replied, "If it pleases God".

'The Governor General's letter was then delivered to Shuja . . . Elphinstone explained the causes and objects of his mission, to which the Shah was pleased to give the most gracious replies and flattering assurances.' The British visitors were invested in robes of honour, after which they rose and rode home in them.

Late that night, Fraser sat up and wrote to his parents about the impression Shuja had made on him: 'I was particularly struck with the dignity of his appearance,' he scribbled, 'and the romantic Oriental awe which his situation, person and Majesty impressed on me.' He went on:

> The king sat with his legs doubled under, but in an erect posture, not reclining, each hand resting on the upper part of the thigh, the elbows sticking out. This is the posture which fierce